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Fate's Edge
large The Amaranthine Core

Three Voices of the Road
(with apologies to the sea)

→day

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For the GM – The Spider, the Snake, the Raven

The three Omens (**Inaea**, **Isoka**, **Ikasha**) are not gods. They are forces that appear in whispers, dreams, and the spaces between counted things. Do not introduce them directly. Instead, let players encounter their echoes:

tem A rope that never frays (Inaea) tem A judgment that cuts clean (Isoka) tem A dream that feels too real (Ikasha)

By the time players learn the names, they should have already felt their presence for many sessions.

The full truth of the Omens – the Clockwork Demon, the scouring of civilisations, Ikasha’s imprisonment in Obishaal – is **endgame content**. Use the fragments in this book as breadcrumbs:

tem If players ask a Pereshi fire-keeper about the “serpent judge,” they will receive a riddle. tem If they ask a Tulkani about the “dreamer,” they will receive a story. tem If they ask a Sidhi about the “spider,” they will receive a knot and a warning: *“Do not pull it unless you are ready to see what it holds.”*

The Hollow is the interest on the Omens’ oldest debt. The players are never meant to pay it off – only to decide whose name goes on the next line of the ledger.

Preface: Three Voices

This book is not a travel guide. It is a collection of thresholds: bridges that remember every toll, fog-bells that count your breaths, stones that warm when you speak a true name. Three travellers have walked these roads before you. They have agreed to lend their voices to the pages that follow. Listen to each; they will disagree, and that is the point.

Lady Isolde of the Scar, Fifth of Her Name wline *“The sun shattered at Lence. The pieces are still falling. Which shadow will catch you?”*

I am Isolde, and I have worn a gorget to three tournaments, buried two brothers, and learned that chivalry is not a code – it is a weight. You carry it or it crushes you. There is no third option. My family has held the valley north of Rouen since before the Fenwoods burned Lence. In the high season we joust; in the low season we scheme. The Belworth River is our border and our wound. I speak for Vhasia, for Viterra, for the hedge-law courts and the fractured sun. When I tell you a bridge will hold, I have counted its stones. When I warn you a lord cannot be trusted, I have seen the crack in his seal.

The Bravo of Silkstrand (no other name, no other need) wline *“Every bridge is a promise. Every canal carries a secret. But the best secrets are the ones you share over wine.”*

I am nobody – or I was, once. The canals of Silkstrand do not care about your bloodline. They care about your stroke with an oar and your aim with a dagger. I started as a dock-rat, became a duelist, and now I am something else: a witness to the city that never sleeps. The Exchange closes at midnight, but the bargains never end. I have won purses and lost friends, and I still smile. Why? Because the sun rises over the laguna every morning, and there is always another bridge to cross. I speak for Silkstrand, for the Brass Coast, for the Sidhi freedmen who taught me that freedom is a story you tell yourself until it becomes true.

The Edgewalker (Aeler, name forgotten by design) wline *“The mountain breathes. The stone remembers. I am the crack in both.”*

I am an Aeler Edgewalker. You call us mountain-dwellers who measure breath in silver bells and seal our agreements in keystone. How quaint. We don’t just measure breath – we know the load each lung can bear. When a Tulkani chieftain swears an oath on his firstborn? That’s not honour – it’s a keystone I’ve already wedged into three different seals. The first crack was his. The second was mine. When a Veiled Sister binds a demon? That’s not terror – it’s a fault line I’ve traced in the bedrock. The first tremor was hers. The second is coming. You see the surface as “full of problems.” I see the weight in the stone, the strain in the beam. Problems are not obstacles – they are the pressure that shapes the mountain. I speak for the Aeler, for the Mistlands, for the deep vaults where the Hollow is not a myth but a flaw in the foundation. When I tell you a tunnel is sound, I have walked its stress lines. When I tell you to flee, trust the stone’s memory.

The three of us have walked these roads. We have paid our tolls – in blood, in silver, in silence. Use the cards to find your own. When you are lost, ask: *What does this place witness? And what does it ask in return?*

Then listen. The road is patient. The Hollow is patient. We are not. But we have left the lamp lit for you.

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The Cartomancer's Compass

labelchap:cartomancercompass

The Memory of the Deck

The world does not speak in words. It speaks in suits, ranks, and the spaces between. Every bridge, every bribe, every broken oath can be laid out on a table of felt and dealt from a worn deck. This is not superstition. It is method.

The regional generators in this book – from the fogchoked levees of the Mistlands to the walking cities of Ngomebe – all speak the same language: the language of the fiftytwocard deck. Learn to read it, and you can generate a campaign, a crossroads, or a crisis in the time it takes to shuffle.

This chapter is your key. It explains how to interpret any card drawn from any regional generator, and how to weave those interpretations into the fiction at your table. Consider it the threshold between the abstract mechanics of the draw and the living, breathing world of Fate's Edge.

The Four Suits: A Universal Grammar

Every card in every generator carries the same four suitmeanings. They are the alphabet of the world's witness.

0.0.1 Spades: Place The Stage

labelsec:spadesplace

Where does the scene happen? is the threshold, the landmark, the ground beneath the action. It answers: *Where are we?*

tem **High rank (10–A)**: A major landmark – a fortress, a capital, a haunted ruin. The place has a name that echoes in local songs. tem **Mid rank (6–9)**:

A functional location – a ford, a market, a shrine. The place has a purpose and a keeper. tem **Low rank (2–5)**: A liminal or neglected place – a crossroads, a collapsed bridge, a smuggler’s cove. The place is defined by what it lacks.

In the regional chapters, entries are always places. See, for example, the bridges and canals of Silkstrand or the cairns and passes of Ubral.

0.0.2 Hearts: Actor The Face

labelsec:heartsactor

Who drives the scene? is the person, the faction, the voice that speaks. It answers: *Who is here?*

tem **High rank (J–A)**: An elite, a ruler, a powerbroker. The actor has authority and reach beyond the immediate scene. tem **Mid rank (6–10)**: A professional, a functionary, a skilled operator. The actor has a trade and a price. tem **Low rank (2–5)**: A commoner, an outcast, a victim. The actor needs something or has been failed by someone.

In the regional chapters, entries are always people or factions. See the merchants and spies of the Brass Coast or the spiritwardens of the Mistlands.

0.0.3 Clubs: Pressure The Complication

labelsec:clubspressure

What pushes back? is the storm, the burden, the knife in the dark. It answers: *What goes wrong?*

tem **High rank (10–A)**: A catastrophe, a betrayal, an invasion. The complication changes the shape of the journey. tem **Mid rank (6–9)**: A serious obstacle – a feud, a quarantine, a broken bridge. The complication costs time, resources, or reputation. tem **Low rank (2–5)**: A minor hazard – a sudden squall, a lost token, a raised toll. The complication is a nuisance, not a disaster.

In the regional chapters, entries are always complications or threats. See the river floods and witnesscord cuts of Ayokha or the market riots of Silkstrand.

0.0.4 Diamonds: Leverage The Reward

labelsec:diamondsleverage

What opens the door? is the token, the writ, the secret that changes Position. It answers: *What do you gain?*

tem **High rank (J–A)**: A major asset – a noble title, a keystone charter, a general pardon. The reward reshapes the party’s standing. tem **Mid rank (6–10)**: A significant tool – a passstone, a witness cord, a lighthouse charter. The reward solves a specific class of problem. tem **Low rank (2–5)**: A minor advantage – a bridge token, a guestcup, a rumour. The reward grants a single use of improved Position.

In the regional chapters, entries are always rewards or leverage. See the keystone charters of Ngomebe or the watershare tablets of Fhara.

Rank and Severity: The Weight of the Card

labelsec:rankseverity

The rank of a card – from Ace (high) to 2 (low) – sets the scale of its suit’s meaning. Use this ladder:

line Rank	Narrative Weight
line Ace	Legendary, campaignaltering, mythic
King/Queen/Jack	Major, factionlevel, lasting consequences
10–7	Significant, scenedefining, costly
6–4	Moderate, manageable, a real cost
3–2	Minor, a complication but not a crisis
line	

When a generator instructs you to set a timer by the highest rank, use this conversion:

tem **2–5**: 4segment timer (short, local problem) tem **6–10**: 6segment timer (standard, journeylength) tem **J, Q, K**: 8segment timer (extended, regional problem) tem **A**: 10segment timer (epic, campaignlength)

Card Faces: The Court as Character

labelsec:courtcharacters

Face cards (Jack, Queen, King) are not merely high ranks. They are *persons* with agency, personality, and often a name.

tem **Jack**: An agent, a functionary, a messenger. The Jack acts on someone else's authority. They are competent but replaceable. tem **Queen**: A power in their own right. The Queen has influence, resources, and a network. They are not easily replaced. tem **King**: The ultimate authority in their domain. The King is the source of law, the peak of the hierarchy. To challenge a King is to challenge the order itself.

When a face card appears in a (actor) draw, give the NPC a name, a motive, and a quirk. When it appears in a (place) or (pressure) draw, treat it as a *personified* force: a King of Clubs might be a feud that has lasted generations; a Queen of Spades might be a bridge that remembers every toll.

Aces and the Ninth: The Hollow's Attention

labelsec:acesninth

An Ace is not merely the highest rank. It is a *threshold*. When an Ace appears in any draw, the Hollow takes notice. The GM gains 1 extra Story Beat (beyond any generated by 1s) to spend on a supernatural complication: a ghostly procession, a bell that rings without a clapper, a shadow that walks independently.

In regions where the Ninth Taboo is strong (Theona, Aelinnel, Ways Between), an Ace may also trigger a specific regional omen. For example:

tem In Theona, an Ace of might add a “missing step” to a bridge. tem In the Ways Between, an Ace of might cause a reflection to speak. tem In the Mistlands, an Ace of might cause a bellline to fail.

The GM should always read an Ace as a signal to escalate the uncanny.

By the Numbers: Procedure for Any Generator

labelsec:generatorprocedure

When you sit down to generate a scene, a journey leg, or a settlement, follow this procedure:

tem **Name the destination**. Which region? Which route? Which authority controls the gate? tem **Shuffle and draw**. Draw cards faceup, one for each

suit you need. Most generators require all four suits; some (like travel legs) may use only three. tem **Read the** . This is your place. Describe it first. Set the stage. tem **Read the** . This is your actor. Introduce them. What do they want? Why are they here? tem **Read the** . This is your pressure. Complicate the scene. What just went wrong, or what is about to? tem **Read the** . This is your leverage. What can the players gain if they succeed? Be specific. tem **Set the timer**. Use the highest rank among the four cards to determine the size of the scene's primary timer (see above). tem **Interpret faces and Aces**. Give names to face cards. Apply regional Ace effects. tem **Play to find out**. Use the generated elements as prompts, not scripts. The cards are seeds, not fences.

Regional Flavours: How Suits Shift Meaning

labelsec:regionalflavours

While the core suit meanings remain constant, each region inflects them with its own texture. A in Ecktoria is a forum or a coinhouse; a in the Valewood is a phasing ruin or a starroad. A in the Black Banners is a mercenary captain or a condotta broker; a in Ykrul is a khatun or a bonesinger.

Use the regional chapters as your lexicon. When you draw a card, consult the relevant table. The tables are designed to evoke the specific flavour of the region.

Example: A Draw in Acasia

You are running a journey through the Broken Marches. You draw:

7, J, 4, Q

tem **7**: HillMotte – Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops. tem **J**: Bride with No Dowry but a Claim – Daggers in the wedding chest. tem **4**: Wedding Turns Ambush – You are caught between two bloodlines. tem **Q**: Marriage Proxy – From the Margravine; bind a hillking to your cause. tem **Highest rank**: Queen (equivalent to 8). The scene's primary timer is 8 segments: *The Feud Escalates* [8]. tem **Interpretation**: The party arrives at a hillfort on the eve of a wedding. The bride is caught between two feuding bloodlines. The wedding turns to violence. If the party can survive the ambush and broker peace, the Margravine will grant them a Marriage Proxy – a powerful tool to

bind a hillking to their cause. The 8segment timer tracks how quickly the feud spirals into open war.

This is the generator at work: four cards, one scene, immediate fiction.

The Unwritten Suit: When a Draw is Incomplete

labelsec:incompletedraw

Sometimes, a generator does not require all four suits. A travel leg may only need , , . A social encounter might only need and . When a suit is missing, treat its absence as a question:

tem **No** : The place is ambiguous, shifting, or hidden. The scene occurs in a liminal space – a crossroads, a fogbank, a threshold. tem **No** : The actor is absent, silent, or dead. The pressure and place act without a face. This can be more frightening than a named NPC. tem **No** : The scene is calm, peaceful, or mercifully straightforward. This is rare in Fate’s Edge. Treasure it. tem **No** : The reward is not a token but an outcome. The players gain Position, information, or a cleared timer rather than a physical asset.

Interpreting Any Draw, Any Region

labelsec:anydraw

When you need a prompt in a hurry – a random encounter, a rumour at a tavern, a discovery in a ruin – draw a single card. Use this quickreference:

line	A place or landmark. What is its name? What happened here?
	A person or faction. What do they want? What do they fear?
	A complication or threat. Who or what is the obstacle?
	A reward, token, or secret. What can be gained?
line	

The rank tells you the scale. A low rank is local and personal; a high rank is regional and political. A face card demands a name; an Ace demands the Hollow’s attention.

Final Guidance: The Cards Are Oracles, Not Scripts

labelsec:cardsoracles

The generators in this book are tools, not tyrants. If a draw gives you an entry that contradicts established fiction, or if you simply prefer a different interpretation, overrule it. The deck is a prompt, not a prison.

But trust it, too. The most memorable sessions often come from the card you did not expect. The Ace that arrives at the wrong moment. The Jack who speaks a name no one wanted to hear. The diamond that glows with a secret.

Shuffle. Draw. Interpret. And let the road unfold.

“The road is never closed. It is only passed to the next walker.” fill — Dusana of the Raven Road

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Part I

The Amaranthine Sea Northern Shores

“The sea keeps a better memory than any scribe. The reef remembers every secret whispered above its depths. Do not ask which flag flies highest – ask which hull leaks slowest.”

— The Bravo of Silkstrand

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Kahfagia

The Flag of Storms.

“Kahfagia runs on lantern-light and rust, where the lies are as polite as the lanterns that never go out. Every beacon is a promise – and every reef remembers the ships that broke theirs. Come for the salt fish, stay for the gossip, but never trust a calm tide: the commodores know the lanterns fear the dark, and I’ve seen a Mirror-Keeper weep when her reflection showed her a daughter she’d sold for a pilot’s license.”

— The Bravo of Silkstrand

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish porridge – dried cod soaked overnight, boiled with hardtack and a splash of lamp oil. Every Kahfagian child learns to taste the salt and know which coast their grandmother came from.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count ships by their lanterns. Three lanterns means a Kahfagian merchant – safe. Four means an Oshiiran grain barge – neutral. One, low in the water, means a privateer. Run.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their hands. Dock-workers have rope-burned palms. Merchants have ink-stained fingers. Privateers have no fingernails – they bite them off in storms.

What is the most common crime? False manifests. Every third ship carries cargo that doesn’t appear on its papers. The Admiralty knows. The Admiralty takes a cut. The Admiralty calls it a “tariff surcharge.”

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Mirror-Keepers are not born – they are made. And the making requires a death. A sister, a daughter, a lover. Someone who drowned so the keeper could see through the fog.

Where do people go when they die? The tide takes them. Kahfagia has no cemeteries above ground. The drowned are weighted with chain and dropped in the deep channel. Their families light candles in paper boats and float them out at dusk.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer your bell. Every Kahfagian carries a small brass bell – the sound of their name. Offering it means “I give you my voice.” Refusing to return it is a declaration of blood feud.

What is the most important festival? The Beacon Lighting (midwinter). Every lighthouse keeper lights a new lamp from the Admiral's flame. If your beacon catches first, your year will be lucky. If it sputters, you will owe a death to the sea.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Admiral's lantern code has a ninth signal – never used, never spoken, burned into every keeper's memory. It means "*Kill the witnesses. Sink the evidence. The sea will hide the rest.*"

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Ecktoria

Marble Fire.

“Ecktoria is a marble coffin for a king who never was. The Everflame burns not for light but for weight – it measures the lie in every breath. The statues are not watchers – they are the pressure points in the stone. The undertakers know the body is cold, but the pressure remains. The mountain does not forget what the marble tries to hide.”

— Aeler Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? Spiced flatbread dipped in olive oil and honey – but only if you can afford the honey. The poor eat millet porridge with a single dried fig. The fig is counted as part of the household’s grain allowance.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count coins by touch. Every Ecktorian child has a box of worn sesterces; by age five, they can tell a debased copper from pure silver by the weight alone.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their signature. Ecktorians judge by handwriting before face. A clerk with a steady hand is trustworthy. A noble with a flourish is hiding something. A merchant who signs with an X is not worth doing business with.

What is the most common crime? Tax evasion – but it is not a crime, it is a sport. Every household keeps two ledgers: the white one for the Censor, the red one for the family. The art is in keeping the red ledger from looking like a confession.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Censor’s clerks are paid to find discrepancies. They are also paid to lose them. The price of a lost discrepancy is exactly 5

Where do people go when they die? The family crypt, beneath the basilica floor. The wealthy are burned, their ashes mixed with marble dust and pressed into the floor tiles. The poor are buried in unmarked graves outside the walls. The Everflame’s light does not reach that far.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You petition the Censor to have

the wrong stricken from the public record. The petition costs a tenth of your annual income. If accepted, the wrong is erased – legally, it never happened. If rejected, the wrong is published, and you lose your civic standing.

What is the most important festival? The Triumph of the Flame (autumn equinox). The basilica’s central flame is carried in procession through every district. To touch the flame is to be absolved of petty debts. To be burned by it is a sign that your debts are not petty.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Grand Magistrate’s seal is a forgery. The original cracked in 783 AR. The current seal was carved by a prison engraver who was executed to keep the secret. The engraver’s apprentice is still alive. They live in Silkstrand. They have the original sketches.

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Acasia

The Broken Marches.

“Acasia was the first province the Utaran Empire swallowed and the last it spat out. Now it is a wound that will not close – a place where roads loop back on themselves and bridges lead to the same shore. The Curse is not a spell. It is a memory, and the land has a very long memory. In these marches, memory is the only currency that does not devalue.”

— Lady Isolde of the Scar

What do people eat for breakfast? Hardtack soaked in broth – if you have broth. If not, hardtack and hope. The granaries have been empty for three winters. The merchants sell grain at famine prices. The duke says the roads are too dangerous for caravans. The farmers say the duke owns the caravans.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To name the dead. Every Acasian child has a list of ancestors they repeat at bedtime. The list gets shorter each generation. Not because children forget. Because the dead are forgetting themselves.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Whether they have a shadow. The Curse takes shadows first. A man without a shadow is not cursed – he is already gone. His body just hasn’t stopped moving yet.

What is the most common crime? Bridge-toll evasion. The roads are unsafe, the ferries are unreliable, but the barons still demand payment for crossings no one can make. The crime is not in refusing to pay. The crime is in being caught trying.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Curse began with a promise broken on the Blackwood Bridge. A baron promised his daughter to a lord of the old forest. He married her to a lowland knight instead. The forest remembered. The forest is still waiting for the wedding.

Where do people go when they die? Into the Blackwood. Burial is forbidden – the ground rejects the dead. Bodies are carried to the tree-line and left. The wood takes them. Sometimes, at dusk, you can see them walking between the trunks. They do not look back.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You walk the Broken Mile – a stretch of road that collapsed into the river a decade ago. If you reach the far side, you are forgiven. If you fall, you were not sorry enough. No one has reached the far side in seven years.

What is the most important festival? The Counting of the Names (midwinter). Every village lists its dead aloud, from oldest to newest. If a name is forgotten, the ghost walks until someone remembers. The list grows longer each year. The memory grows shorter.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The duke's son is a ghoul. He was lost in the Blackwood as a child. They found him three days later, pale and smiling. He does not age. He does not eat. He only watches. The servants know. The servants do not speak.

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Vhasia

The Fractured Sun.

“The sun shattered at Lence. The pieces are still falling. Which shadow will catch you? The Fenwoods burned the capital a decade ago, but the fire never went out – it just moved indoors, into every court, every negotiation, every marriage bed. Chivalry is the mask; the knife is the truth.”

— Lady Isolde of the Scar

What do people eat for breakfast? Dark bread and watered wine – the wine cuts the dust from the road. The nobility eat spiced eggs and fresh cheese, but they eat behind closed doors. To eat well in public is to invite envy. Envy is a dagger.

What does a child learn before they can walk? Which colours not to wear. Black and gold are the Northern Crown’s colours. Red and silver are the Southern Parlement’s. A child who wears the wrong colour to the wrong village may not return home.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Which side of the road they walk on. The north side is the Crown’s. The south side is the Parlement’s. The middle is no man’s land – literally. Bandits, spies, and messengers use the middle. So do ghosts.

What is the most common crime? Raiding across the Belworth. The river is the border, the border is a suggestion, and the suggestion is enforced by armed men on both sides. The crime is not in raiding. The crime is in being caught on the wrong bank at dawn.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Sun-court was not burned. It was bankrupted. The Fenwoods did not sack Lence – they bought it. Every judge, every clerk, every guard captain had a price. The Fenwoods paid it. The Vhasians are still paying interest.

Where do people go when they die? To the crypts beneath the Sun-court – if they can afford a plaque. The poor are buried in unmarked graves along the Belworth floodplain. The river floods every spring. The dead wash downstream, into

the land of the other crown. Neither side claims them.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a chevauchée – a raiding party that burns a village in your name. The apology is not in the burning. The apology is in the promise that the village will be rebuilt with your own hands.

What is the most important festival? The Sun-return (spring equinox). Both crowns claim the sun as their symbol. On this day, both hold processions. The processions are identical. The participants do not acknowledge each other. The sun does not care.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Queen-Mother has no claim to the regency. Her son is not the Dauphin. The real Dauphin died in childbirth. The child on the throne is a foundling, bought from a Tulkani caravan. The Tulkani know. The Tulkani are still waiting to be paid.

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Viterra

The Hedge-Law Realm.

“Viterra hums with the quiet hum of old promises kept. The Queen’s Peace is not a word – it is a wax seal warm from the press, and every seal tells a story. The hedge-courts don’t keep the peace with swords – they keep it with second chances. And in Viterra, a second chance is always worth the price of a smile.”

— The Bravo of Silkstrand

What do people eat for breakfast? Barley porridge with a drizzle of honey – if you own bees. If not, porridge with salt. Salt is the currency of the poor. Honey is the currency of the hopeful.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To recite their lineage back three generations. Every Viterran child knows their grandparents’ names, trades, and debts. A child who cannot recite is a child without standing. Standing is everything.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Whether they carry a seal ring. A seal ring means they have the right to make contracts in their own name. A stranger without a seal ring is either a servant or a criminal. In Viterra, the difference is a matter of paperwork.

What is the most common crime? Boundary disputes. A hedge moved three feet east. A milestone replaced under cover of darkness. A ford declared “private” when it has been public for two centuries. The courts are clogged. The lawyers are rich. The hedges are patient.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Queen is not a warrior. She has never drawn a sword. Her reputation was forged by a propaganda campaign run by her spymaster. The spymaster is dead. His successor is more discreet.

Where do people go when they die? To the family plot – if they have a family. The landless poor are buried in parish cemeteries, their headstones marked with a single word: “Anonymous.” The ghosts wander the hedgerows at dusk. They do not remember their names. They remember their debts.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You petition the hedge-court for a “writ of contrition.” You state your wrong aloud while holding a handful of earth from the wronged party’s land. If the earth crumbles, you are forgiven. If it holds, you are not.

What is the most important festival? The Opening of the Rolls (autumn). Every county sends its tax records to the capital. The documents are carried by children, so the next generation learns the weight of obligation.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Codex of Precedents has a missing page. It was torn out during a trial for treason. The page contained the precedent for executing a monarch. The Queen knows. The Justiciars know. The page is hidden in a lead-lined box beneath the hedge-court at Thornwood.

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Thepyrgos

City of a Thousand Stairs.

“Thepyrgos is a vertical labyrinth of stair-rights, rope-guilds, and synod edicts that shift with the tide. The Synod rules with the delicacy of a brick wrapped in velvet – they hate unsanctioned magic, but they adore infrastructure. Beneath the city, the Unfinished Stair waits for those who ask a question the Synod cannot answer.”

— The Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? Flatbread with olive oil and a boiled egg – if you are a clerk. If you are a student, bread and water. If you are a professor, bread, water, and a single fig. The fig is a status symbol. The status is “I have not been audited.”

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a bell schedule. Thepyrgos runs on bells – dawn bells, market bells, curfew bells, trial bells. A child who cannot read the bells cannot cross the city without a guardian. A child without a guardian is a child who will be sold to the university for dissection.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their step count. Thepyrgos has a thousand stairs. A stranger who counts them aloud is either a pilgrim or a spy. A stranger who climbs them in silence is either a native or a ghost.

What is the most common crime? Unsanctioned magic. The Synod licenses every spell cast within the walls. An unlicensed cantrip is a misdemeanour. An unlicensed healing is a felony. An unlicensed summoning is a death sentence – not for the caster, who will be executed, but for the summoned, who will be bound to the city’s foundation as a “structural consultant.”

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Silent Stair is not silent. It whispers the confessions of dead scholars – their secrets recorded in the stone. The Chain-Lanterns listen. They do not share.

Where do people go when they die? To the catacombs beneath the university. The catacombs are a library of bones. Each skeleton is labelled with the scholar’s name, their thesis, and the date of their death. The unlabelled bones are

the ones who died before they could finish. They are still writing.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You submit a “retraction” to the Synod’s Committee on Ethical Correction. The retraction is published in the public square, read aloud by a herald, and witnessed by three notaries. The fee is 50 silver. The shame is free.

What is the most important festival? The Convocation of the Steps (summer solstice). Every citizen climbs the thousand stairs to the upper citadel. The Archon reads the names of the dead from the past year. The names are carved into the steps as they are read. The steps are getting crowded.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Archon is a fraud. He never passed the Synod’s examination. His degree was purchased from a disgraced dean whose signature is forged on every document. The forger is still alive. They live in the catacombs. They have the original quill.

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Part II

The Northern Reaches

“The mountain counts your breaths. The frost writes your name in ice. In the north, the dead do not wait – they walk, and they remember every promise you made to keep warm.”

— The Edgewalker

Aeler

Crowns Under-Vaults.

“The Aeler hold the mountains by breath, bell, and load-bearing stone. Air is measured, water is bartered, light is rationed – and every tunnel has a breaking point. I’ve mapped most of them. The ones I haven’t are still settling.”

— The Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? Stone-bread and cave cheese – the bread is baked on heated stone slabs, the cheese is aged in sealed galleries. The cheese has been aging for three generations. It is an heirloom. It is also barely edible.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count their breaths. Aeler children wear breath-counters – small brass bells. Eight breaths, ring the bell. Nine breaths, run. A child who cannot count will not survive the winter.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their bell. Every Aeler carries a bell tuned to their breath. A stranger’s bell rings at a different pitch. A mismatched bell is a warning. A silent bell is a threat.

What is the most common crime? Air theft. In the deep vaults, ventilation is shared. A sealed door, a blocked vent – these are thefts of breath, punishable by breath-debt. The guilty party donates their own air ration to the victim. The donation is measured in days. The days are counted by bells.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The True Masons are not neutral. They are the Vault-Queen’s eyes. Every “independent” repair, every “neutral” inspection – the True Masons are watching. They do not report to the Queen. They are the Queen.

Where do people go when they die? To the Deep Vaults. The dead are sealed in niches carved into the walls, their names chiselled above their heads. The niches are reused every century. The names are never erased. The dead share walls with strangers. The strangers are patient.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a keystone – a load-bearing stone from your own holding. It is installed in the wronged party’s

wall. If it holds, you are forgiven. If it cracks, the claim stands. If it crumbles, your holding collapses. Apology is architecture. Architecture is law.

What is the most important festival? The Ringing of the Underways (deep winter). Every bell in every hold is rung eight times. The sound travels through the stone, a heartbeat that reminds the mountain that the living are still here. The dead listen. The dead do not ring back.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Vault-Queen is a construct. Assembled after the real queen died in a cave-in. Her heart is a keystone. Her breath is a bellows. The True Masons have the schematics. The schematics are missing three pages – the pages that describe how to turn her off.

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The Mistlands

Bells, Salt, and Breath.

“The Mistlands lend their name to the Aeler, but the fog is its own master. It hides not just the land, but the law that should bind us. The bell-lines ring to keep the wraiths back, and the Aeler ask for their due – but when the coin is gone, they take their bells and leave. Then the fog does not forget; it remembers every name they left behind in the damp and dark.”

— Lady Isolde of the Scar

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish and sour bread – the fish is smoked over peat fires, the bread is leavened with fog-damp yeast. The yeast is caught in cloth traps hung from bell-towers. The yeast is not alive. It is not dead either.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To ring a bell. Every Mistlands child is given a small bronze bell at birth. By age three, they can ring the eight notes of the ward-chime. The ninth note is never taught. Discovery is fatal.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their salt-pouch. A stranger without a pouch is a fool. A stranger with an empty pouch is a fool about to become a wraith.

What is the most common crime? Ward-salt theft. The Aeler control the salt pans, and the salt is the only thing that keeps the dead from rising. A stolen pouch buys a week’s protection. The price is a year’s labour in the deep galleries. The cycle is perpetual.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Bell-Wardens are not chosen – they are volunteered. The training holds are in the mountains. The mountains are cold. The ones who return do not speak of what they learned. Their bells ring at a different pitch.

Where do people go when they die? To the fog. Bodies are left at the edge of the bell-line. The mist takes them. Sometimes, at dusk, you can see them walking the lanes. They do not speak. Their presence is a question.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You ring the Bell of Atonement – a cracked bronze bell in every village square. Ring it once for each wrong confessed. If the bell rings true, you are forgiven. If it shatters, you are banished to the fog. The banished never return. Their voices still answer from the white.

What is the most important festival? The Rehanging of the Lines (autumn). Every bell-line is taken down, cleaned, and rehung. The villages are silent for three nights. The dead listen. The dead wait. The dead do not ring.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Legate of the Mists is a wraith. She died in 803 AR, during a bell-line failure. The Aeler rebuilt her from fog and memory. She does not know she is dead. She signs documents. Her signature fades after sunset.

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Ykrul

Wolf Standards, Winter Camps.

“The Ykrul ride the Violet Steppe, where the sky is a cup and the horizon its lip. Their Kon’reh is not a code but a compass – it reads the land in steps, in stops, in the weight of a breath. Every crossing has its cost, every ford its toll, every feud its balance in the space between hoof and earth. But the Steppe does not deal in coin; it deals in the weight of a promise and the length of a life.”

— Aeler Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? Fermented mare’s milk and dried meat – the milk is drunk warm from the skin, the meat is sliced thin and dried on saddle-pommels. The meat carries the taste of horse sweat. The milk carries the taste of the steppe.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To sit a horse. Ykrul children are placed on a horse before they can stand. A child who falls learns to hold tighter. A child who cannot ride cannot eat.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their braids. Red for the Wolf Clan, black for the Iron Horse, grey for the Salt Steppe. A stranger whose braids are cut has been shamed. A stranger with no braids has no clan. A stranger with no clan is prey.

What is the most common crime? Horse theft. A stolen horse is a stolen relative. The price is blood – the thief’s or the owner’s. The evidence is the horse’s memory. Horses do not lie.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Khagan is not chosen by blood. He is chosen by the horse. Every five years, the clan chiefs lead their best stallions to the sacred ring. The horse that steps forward first chooses the next Khagan. The horse has not stepped forward in twenty years.

Where do people go when they die? To the sky. Bodies are placed on open platforms, left for the wind and birds. The bones are ground into powder, mixed with clay, fired into beads. The beads are worn by the dead’s descendants. The

beads are warm. The warmth is memory.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a hostage string – a braided cord that ties your wrist to the wronged party’s. The cord is cut when the apology is accepted. If the cord is never cut, you are bound. The binding is lifelong. The binding is called “friend.”

What is the most important festival? The First Grass (spring equinox). The herds are released onto new pasture. The riders race to the horizon and back. The winner names the summer camps. The loser tends the sick animals. The loser always wins next year.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Sky-Speaker is a fraud. She cannot call storms. She cannot read omens. She is a horse-witch who learned to read the clouds. The clouds are reliable. The Khagan does not want to know.

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Vilikari

Laurels Longhouses.

“The Vilikari live in the space between marble and felt, where treaties are not written in law but woven in need. The emperors gave us their chisel, the chieftains gave us their knot – and where they meet, we find a strength that is not in the stone or the string, but in the space between. We do not forget the argument; we remember that the space between is where we build.”

— The Bravo of Silkstrand

What do people eat for breakfast? Oatmeal with dried berries – the berries are harvested from the border scrub, where the empire’s orchards meet the steppe’s wild brambles. The berries taste of both. The oatmeal tastes of neither.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To speak both languages – Imperial Utaran and the steppe cant. A child who speaks only one will never cross the border. A child who crosses the border comes back with stories. Listening is power.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Which side of the road they ride on. The empire’s roads are measured from the centre. The steppe’s paths are measured from the edge. A stranger who rides in the ditch is a spy.

What is the most common crime? Treaty-splitting – selling the same rights to both sides. The crime is not in the selling. It is in getting caught before you cross the border.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Foedus Stone is a copy. The original was stolen by a Vilikari trader who owed favours on both sides. She melted it down and sold the marble dust as “treaty-strengthening powder.” The treaties are still holding.

Where do people go when they die? To the border. Buried at the edge – close enough for imperial priests to pray, close enough for steppe shamans to chant. The dead are planted face-up, so they can see both skies. The skies are different colours. The dead do not complain.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You invoke the mallus – the oak-ring court. The wrongdoer circles the ring three times, speaking their apology. On the third circuit, the elders judge. If rejected, the ring closes. Outside is the lawless land. The lawless land is where the wolves are.

What is the most important festival? The Renewal of the Foedus (summer solstice). The stone is washed with milk and honey. The milk is from a Ykrul mare. The honey is from an imperial apiary. The ceremony takes all day.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Foedus Stone has a crack. It was repaired with clay and prayer. The clay is drying. The prayer is fading. When the stone splits, the treaty splits with it. No one knows what happens then.

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Black Banners

Condotta Crowns.

“Mercenary companies trade steel for coin – today’s shield, tomorrow’s spear. Ecktorian treasuries do not contain the border war; they stoke it with gold. Between them walk the Ykrul clans, the Vilikari tribes, and the legionaries who remember when a word was a bond.”

— Aeler Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? Hardtack and camp stew – the stew is whatever was caught, killed, or traded for before dawn. The cook is called “The Alchemist.” No one asks their real name.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count coin. Camp children tally pay shares before they can read. A child who miscounts goes hungry. A child who goes hungry learns to count faster.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their colours. Every company has its own banner – lantern, thorn, bell, fishbone, broken scale. A stranger with no colours has no company. A stranger with no company is a deserter. A deserter is a corpse.

What is the most common crime? Desertion – but desertion is a negotiation. A soldier who wants to leave will sell their gear, their secrets, and their silence. The price is always “one more season.”

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Black Colonel is not a person. The title is held by a wax seal in a lead-lined box. The box is carried by a mute lieutenant. The lieutenant signs documents with the Colonel’s thumb-print. The thumb-print is a forgery. The forger is the lieutenant. The lieutenant has no thumbs.

Where do people go when they die? To the pyre. Camp dead are burned in a bonfire of broken spears. The quartermaster charges a fee from the dead’s final pay. The final pay is never enough.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You stand a watch. The

wronged party chooses the hour – midnight, dawn, the dead of winter. If you survive, you are forgiven. If you do not, the claim is paid.

What is the most important festival? Payday – but payday is a negotiation. The captain promises payment on the first of the month. The quartermaster promises when the supply train arrives. The soldiers promise loyalty until the payment comes. The payment never comes. The loyalty never ends.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Banner-Captain's contract is written in disappearing ink. The ink was supplied by a Sidhi forger paid in promises. The promises were not kept. The forger is now a camp follower. The forger knows where the contract is hidden.

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The Linns

Skerries Storm-Oaths.

“North of the Aberderrin Sea, where fjords split the coast and skerries break the tide, dwell the Linn. They are not just traders and raiders; they are keepers of the storm’s oath and the sea’s weight. Their longships fill the whale-road and the river mouths, not for plunder, but for the promise of the tide. They swear oaths to storm and sea – not as words, but as a weight that binds, a clause that the deep remembers. They do not pay in silver; they pay in stories, because a tale well-told is the only treasure that lasts when the gold is gone.”

— Lady Isolde of the Scar

What do people eat for breakfast? Seal blubber and flatbread – the blubber is chewy, the bread is dense, and both are stored in the same barrel. The barrel is shared with the crew. The crew shares everything. Family is obligation.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To tie a knot. Linn children are given a length of rope at birth. By age five, they can tie the eight sea-knots. The ninth knot is for emergencies – and for funerals. The ninth knot is for when the sea asks for a life.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their breath. Linn sailors chew kelp to sweeten their breath. A stranger whose breath smells of salt has been at sea. A stranger whose breath smells of copper has spoken a false oath. The sea will answer.

What is the most common crime? Oath-breaking – but oath-breaking is a storm. The oath-breaker’s ship will founder. Their children will be born with webbed fingers. The sea is patient. The sea does not forget.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Sea-Queen is not a queen. She is a figurehead – literally. Her body is carved from the keel of a ship that sank in 612 AR. Her voice is a recording. The jarls pretend. The pretending keeps the peace.

Where do people go when they die? To the waves. Bodies are placed in

boats and set adrift, weighted with stones carved with their name. If the boat sinks before the horizon, the dead is accepted. If it returns to shore, the dead is cursed. The beaches are littered with their bones.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a storm-oath. Stand on a cliff during a gale and swear your apology to the wind. If the wind carries your words, you are forgiven. If it throws you into the sea, you are not.

What is the most important festival? The Launching of the Longships (spring thaw). The ships are dragged from their winter shelters and blessed with blood and mead. The ships are named after ancestors. The ancestors are listening. The ancestors approve.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Volva of the Mist is a fraud. She cannot see the future. She reads the weather – pressure, wind, the taste of salt on the air. The sailors know. The sailors do not care. A weather-reader is more useful than a seer.

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Part III

The Spaces Between

“The Ways Between do not measure miles. They measure choices. A wrong turn might lead to yesterday. A right turn might lead to a version of yourself who made a different decision – and is still alive to regret it.”

— The Edgewalker

Ubral

The Stone Between Spears.

“Ubral is a land of upland mists, stone cairns, and clan oaths held tighter than iron. Caught between the Aelerian mountains and the lowland courts of Viterra, its hills are scarred by old raids and crowned by watch-fires. Law is written not in charters but in cattle, blood-price, and songs. A guest’s word can buy more than a sword, but one broken vow can spark a feud lasting generations.”

— Lady Isolde of the Scar

What do people eat for breakfast? Oatcakes and skyr – the oats are grown in highland clearings, the skyr is cultured in stone crocks buried in the peat. The peat remembers the old kings. The old kings are buried beneath it.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count cattle. Ubral children are taught the eight breeds of the hills. The ninth breed has no colour – it belongs to the cairn-folk. The dead do not pay taxes.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their guest-token. A token given by their last host. A warm token means recently welcomed. A cold token means travelling long. No token means a spy. Spies are given a rope.

What is the most common crime? Cattle raiding – but raiding is a sport. A stolen cow is a stolen child. The return is a negotiation. The negotiation is a feud. The feud is a song.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Lady of Tor is not the ruler. The cairns rule. The cairns vote at each full moon. Their votes are carried by the wind. The wind speaks to the hearth-aunts. The clan obeys.

Where do people go when they die? To the cairns. Their bones are added to the cairns. The cairns grow taller each year. The oldest cairn has no name. It remembers the first clan.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a wergild – payment in cattle. The cattle are driven to the cairn. If they graze peacefully, you are forgiven. If they scatter, you are not. If they refuse to enter the covenant’s shadow, your claim

is blood.

What is the most important festival? The Gathering of the Clans (autumn). The clans meet at the Great Cairn. The cattle are counted. The songs are sung. The feuds are settled. The dead are named. The hills remember.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Great Cairn is a prison – the tomb of a Vritann king who tried to conquer Ubral and failed. He was buried alive. His ghost votes with the cairns. He votes for war. The cairns have not yet agreed.

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Silkstrand

City of Bridges Dyewater.

“Silkstrand is a city strung across canals and arched bridges, where every crossing is a negotiation and every current carries coin. The silk looms never sleep, the Exchange never closes, and the Archivolt’s notaries seal fates with a drop of wax. The canals are not just water – they are memory. Every bribe, every broken promise, every cargo never declared – the canals remember.”

— The Bravo of Silkstrand

What do people eat for breakfast? Rice porridge with dried fish – the rice is from Oshiiran barges, the fish from Zakov fleets. Both are smuggled. Both are delicious. Both are paid for in favours.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count bridges. The eight bridges of the city: Merchant’s, Weaver’s, Dyer’s, Cooper’s, Pilot’s, Beggar’s, Saint’s, and the ninth – the bridge only there at low tide. The ninth bridge leads to the Sunken Quarter, where promises go to drown.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their ink. Every Silkstrand merchant has a seal-ink stain on their right thumb. Fresh ink means new to the trade. Faded ink means retired. No ink means not a merchant. Not a merchant is not a person.

What is the most common crime? Contract fraud – but fraud is a negotiation. Contracts are written in disappearing ink. The notaries sell the antidote. The antidote is the fee.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Matron is not the ruler. The canals rule. The canals set the prices. The canals decide who drowns. The canals are the city’s memory. The memory is the Matron’s.

Where do people go when they die? To the canals. Bodies are wrapped in silk and sunk in the deep channels. The channels are the city’s archive. The archive is never balanced.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a bridge – a toll paid

to the Bridge-Lords. The toll is calculated by the wronged party's estimate of loss. The silver is melted and poured into the canal. The canal remembers the weight.

What is the most important festival? The Dyeing of the Waters (spring). The dyers empty their vats into the canals. The water turns red, blue, green, gold – the year's fashions. The Matron's favourite colour is the one that sells best. It is also the colour she dyed her own hair.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The canals were dug by a Sidhi engineer paid in promises. The promises were broken. The engineer cursed the city. Every ninth drop of water is a tear. She has been crying for nine centuries.

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Midh-Akhaz

The Violet Gate.

“Midh-Akhaz is not a city. It is a gap in the world where trade is the only law. No walls, no gates – just the smell of horse sweat, cedar smoke, and the copper tang of coin paid in blood. The grass grows tall to conceal the fallen, not to honor them. Ektorian emissaries call it ‘the Brink’ – the edge where coin buys survival. Caravan guards call it home – a temporary respite from the weight of the road. Thieves call it paradise – a place where the only law is the weight of a knife in the belt.”

— Aeler Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? Curd cheese and flatbread – the cheese is from Ykrul herds, the bread baked in dung-fire embers. The poor dip it in salt; the rich dip it in honey stolen from a border hive.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count horses. The eight gaits of a healthy mount. The ninth gait – the death-sprint – is never taught. It is discovered when the rider’s life depends on it.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their braids. Ykrul warriors braid with clan colours. Vilikari traders wear oiled braids with silver beads. A stranger whose braids are loose has just fought. A stranger with no braids is a slave or a ghost. Neither stays long.

What is the most common crime? Grass-right forgery. The Oasis Compact issues branded sticks for grazing rights. A clever carver can duplicate the brand. The penalty is exile into the tall grass at dusk. The grass has no court of appeals.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Khatun is not the only ruler. The Silver Stall stable master knows where every stolen horse sleeps. The Dust Market auctioneer knows the price of every sin. The Iron Well keeper knows the name of everyone who will die before the next grass moon. They meet once a season. The grass records it.

Where do people go when they die? To the grass. Bodies are left beyond the caravan rings. The grass grows tall and green where a body falls. A patch of

deep violet means the dead were not properly mourned. Locals avoid those patches.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a blood-price on the Coin-Weigh Tribunal's scales. If the scale tips in your favour, you are forgiven. If it balances, you owe a story – a true story that makes the wronged party weep. If it does not, you owe a finger.

What is the most important festival? The Grass Moon (autumn equinox). The violet seed-heads glow under moonlight. The tribes ride in a great circle, singing the names of the dead. At midnight, the Khatun pours water onto the earth. If it steams, the Hollow is walking. No one sleeps.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Oasis Compact's original seal was stolen by a Vilikari factor who wanted to control water rights. The factor still lives in the Foreign Quarter under a false name. The seal is hidden in a hollow horse skull buried under the Grass Ring. The skull belonged to the Khatun's favourite stallion. The stallion did not die of old age.

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The Ways Between

Spiritways Veilways.

“The Ways Between do not measure miles. They measure choices. A wrong turn might lead to yesterday. A right turn might lead to a version of yourself who made a different decision – and is still alive to regret it. The mist does not hide landmarks. It hides destinations.”

— The Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? Nothing. There is no breakfast in the Ways Between. No morning, no hunger, only the walking. The walking is sustenance.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To forget. Children born in the Ways Between do not learn. They remember the path they took to be born – eight turns, then the ninth turn is the birth. The birth is a choice. The child does not know they chose.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their direction. A stranger walking toward you may be coming from your future. A stranger walking away may be going to your past. A stranger walking beside you may be yourself from a timeline where you did not turn left. Do not ask.

What is the most common crime? Stealing – but stealing is a paradox. A thief steals a memory from a version of you that no longer exists. The memory never belonged to you. You cannot miss it. You will miss it anyway.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Ways Between are not between anything. They are the only thing that exists. The solid ground you remember – cities, roads, hearths – is the dream. The Ways are the waking. The waking is the walking. The walking never ends.

Where do people go when they die? Deeper. The Ways have no surface, no bottom. The dead walk deeper. The deeper they walk, the less they remember. When they remember nothing, they become the path. The path is the walking. The walking is the dead.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You cannot. Apologies require

memory. Memory requires a self. The Ways erase both. The only apology is to stop walking. Stopping is not an option.

What is the most important festival? There are no festivals. There is only the moment between heartbeats when you realise you have been walking for nine years and you do not remember why. That moment is the festival. Celebrate it by taking the next step.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Wayfinder is not a person. It is the road itself, dreaming of a traveller who will finally reach the end. The end does not exist. The road knows this. The road dreams anyway.

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The Wilds

Roads, Ruins, and Weather.

“Between towns and treaties, the land breathes with patience. Old roads keep the step of armies in their dust; cairns hold the names that no page can contain. Law here is not written in books but in the marks we leave and the debts we owe to the earth – not in coin, but in the weight of a story. To travel is not to conquer the land, but to ask its leave, and the land answers not with silver but with the memory of our passage. The hollows are not holes in the world; they are the lungs of the earth, breathing deep and slow. They do not judge; they do not give. They simply are, and in their being, they teach us to be.”

— The Bravo of Silkstrand

What do people eat for breakfast? Whatever they found – berries, roots, a rabbit snared at dawn. The wilds provide. The wilds also take. The taking is breakfast for something else.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read the sky. Wilds children are taught the eight winds by taste. The ninth wind has no direction – it is the land’s own breath. The land’s breath is a warning.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their pack. Heavy pack means travelling long. Light pack means just started. No pack means a fool or a ghost. The wilds eat fools. Ghosts eat the wilds.

What is the most common crime? Forgetting – but forgetting is a survival strategy. The wilds are full of things that want to be forgotten. A traveller who forgets them may pass safely. A traveller who remembers must pay a toll – a story. The memory is the trap.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The wilds are not empty. They are full of watchers – spirits, beasts, old things with no names. They do not interfere. They wait. They remember every footprint.

Where do people go when they die? Into the land. The dead are left where they fell. The land absorbs them. The land’s memory grows longer. The dead

become the land's memory. The memory is the wilds.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You leave an offering – a coin, a button, a lock of hair. If the offering is gone by morning, you are forgiven. If it remains, you are not. If it has been moved, the land is testing you. The test is the walk. The walk is the apology.

What is the most important festival? The Turning of the Leaves (autumn). The wilds change colour – red is anger, gold is warning, brown is patience, green is forgetfulness. This year the leaves are red. The land is angry. Do not ask why.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The wilds have a heart. A stone buried beneath the oldest oak. The stone is warm and beating. If it stops, the wilds die. Nothing left to remember. Nothing left to wait.

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Dungeons

Living Infrastructure.

“Beneath the surface, ancient places breathe with rusted lungs and dream in currents of forgotten speech. The walls do not forget a step; the air holds the echoes of words we wish we had not spoken. Dungeons are not broken things – they are machines that have learned to live. Their lungs are the vents that sigh, their veins the pipes that throb, their jaws the doors that yield without touch. Some were forged by hand; others grew like mold in the dark. They are not ancient; they are patient, and they remember every flaw in the design as if it were a feature.”

— The Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? Fungus bread and cave water – the fungus grows on the walls, the water drips from the ceiling. Both taste of stone. Both are all there is.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count footsteps. The eight sounds of the deep: Drip, Creak, Groan, Whisper, Scrape, Echo, Silence, and the ninth – the dungeon’s own heartbeat. The heartbeat is a door opening. The door is always behind you.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their shadow. Dungeon shadows are long, even in bright light. A shadow too short means they have been here too long. A shadow that moves independently means they have been touched by the deep. No shadow means they are not a stranger – they are the dungeon’s guest. The dungeon never lets guests leave.

What is the most common crime? Map-making – but map-making is heresy. The dungeon changes its corridors when it feels watched. A map that is accurate at dawn is a lie by dusk. The punishment is to walk the lie until it becomes true.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The dungeon is not a place. It is a creature that dreamed itself into stone. The corridors are its veins. The chambers are its organs. The prisoners are its thoughts. The thoughts are not its own.

Where do people go when they die? Into the walls. Bones are ground into mortar and used to patch the cracks. The cracks always reappear. The dead are never finished being used.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a memory – a true one, witnessed by the dungeon itself. The memory is added to the walls. The walls whisper it back when you sleep. The apology never ends.

What is the most important feature? The Turning of the Keys (whenever the dungeon decides). Locks change, prisoners move, corridors rearrange. There is no date, no warning, no end. It is happening now. You did not notice. That is the point.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The dungeon's architect is still alive, sealed in the lowest chamber. The dungeon does not want to be alone. The architect is its only friend. The architect has not spoken in nine centuries. The dungeon does not need words.

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The Memory Closes

“The road is south. The ink is fresh. The lamp is borrowed.”

fill — Silkstrand Bravo

“The sea does not forgive, but it does forget – if you give it a story worth remembering.”

fill — Lady Isolde

“The ledger is closed. The knife is still sharp. Your name is next.”

fill — Aeler Edgewalker

“The road is a memory. Every oasis is a story, every broken wheel a lesson. The Tulkani tie knots to remember who shared what. The Fhara weigh water before they weigh silver. The Pereshi recite verses to keep the bridges open. And the Sidhi keep lighthouse lamps burning for the dead who still have not reached the shore.”

— Dusana of the Raven Road, at a caravanserai whose name she refused to give

The night air was just shy of frost, and the Three-Mugs Inn smelled of spiced ale, damp wool, and the faint promise of gossip that had been sitting on the bar for a week. The fire crackled low, casting a wavering amber glow over the handful of patrons who pretended not to be listening to each other’s stories.

A soft creak announced the door’s opening. In stepped a woman whose scarred cheek caught the firelight like a fresh-drawn blade. She brushed snow from her cloak, set her sword-hand on the hilt of a well-worn blade, and surveyed the room with the practiced eye of someone who had counted the stones of every bridge she’d crossed.

“Evening,” she said, voice low but carrying. “I’m Isolde of the Scar. Does anyone know if the road north of the Belworth still has that... unsettling gap where the stones whisper?”

A ripple of laughter rose from the corner where a lanky figure leaned back, a grin playing at the corners of his mouth. His cloak was patched with bright dyed patches, and a dagger dangled from his belt like an after-thought. He tipped an imaginary hat.

"Name's... well, I don't really need one, but you can call me Bravo. I've been tracing the canals of Silkstrand all day—turns out the ninth bridge only appears when the tide's feeling generous. You looking for a shortcut, or just a story to trade for a mug?"

From the shadows near the hearth emerged a third figure, tall and gaunt, whose breath seemed to fog the air even as the fire licked his boots. He carried no weapon, only a small brass bell that hung from his neck, silent for now. His eyes were the color of stone-wet after a storm, and he spoke in a tone that made the crackling fire sound like a distant rumble.

"Aeler," he said, the name barely more than a whisper. "I've been walking the old tunnels beneath the Aeler holds. The stone remembers every footfall, and it's been... restless lately. If you're looking for a place that won't collapse under the weight of your expectations, I know a few shafts that still hold."

The trio fell into an uneasy silence, each measuring the other not with suspicion but with the quiet respect of strangers who have walked too many roads to be surprised by another traveler's tale.

Isolde glanced at the bravo's dagger, then at the bell at the Aeler's throat. "You both carry... reminders."

Bravo chuckled, tapping the hilt of his blade. "A reminder that I still owe someone a drink."

Aeler lifted the bell just enough for it to give a faint, reluctant chime. "And a reminder that some debts are measured in breath, not coin."

The innkeeper, a stout woman with a flour-dusted apron, slid three mugs across the bar without a word. The ale was dark, frothy, and smelled faintly of rosemary—exactly the sort of thing that made a warrior think of home, a rogue think of a clever bargain, and a stone-walker think of the weight of a promise kept.

They clinked mugs, the sound a brief, bright note against the low hum of the tavern. No grand quest was sworn, no ancient prophecy whispered. They simply sat, drank, and let the night settle into the familiar rhythm of strangers who, for a moment, shared the same fire, the same stale bread, and the same unspoken understanding that the road ahead would be just as muddy, just as bright, and just as full of stories as the one they'd just left behind.

When the moon rose high enough to silver the snow outside, each rose, tucked their respective token—sword, dagger, bell—back into their packs, and slipped back

into the night. They did not exchange names again; they did not need to. The Three-Mugs Inn would remember them only as the three who came in, shared a drink, and left without making a fuss—exactly the sort of uneventful, perfectly ordinary encounter that makes a tavern worth its name.